

Due to the crucial role it plays, an SSL certificate is issued by an official certificate authority after a thorough verification procedure to confirm the legitimacy of ownership. So, this certificate not only encrypts the communication between websites and audiences, but also ensures the legal position of a site. It plays a vital role in building trust.

As you have now understood why we need a SSL certificate, we can discuss the different types of popular SSL certificates, along with their benefits and issuance procedures.

Domain validation (DV) SSL certificate

The most basic of the three types of SSL certificates, the DV or domain validation certificate confirms the ownership of a domain through an automated online process. All you have to do is to complete a few basic steps to prove that you are the legitimate owner of the domain to get this certificate. Though easiest to get, this type of certificate helps in building only a basic level of trust.

After completing the DV certification procedure, you are allocated trust-building visual elements -- a static seal, a padlock icon, and an HTTPS prefix in your URL.

Cheapest prices and quick, automated processes are the two major benefits of a DV certificate. On the flip side, you get only the basic trust signs that aren't enough to satisfy the security concerns of more demanding customers or visitors.

Important to know: DV misses the most important trust sign — vetting the real, legal business that owns the domain name. For instance, suppose Mr X buys a domain 'abc.com' to lure gullible people into investing money in a business that seems genuine. Being a legitimate domain owner, he can get a DV through an automated process. With HTTPS URLs and other trust signs, it is easy to gain people's trust

too. However, the company (or fraud mechanism) behind this domain isn't vetted/verified, which makes it easier for Mr X to continue duping investors of their hard-earned money.

Is DV SSL the right choice for you?: DV is best for a small and general website, which doesn't demand or require any sensitive information that can be misused like credit card numbers, social security information, or details of a financial portfolio. For websites that post children's stories, general e-magazines, personal blogs, professional portfolios, and other static websites on general topics, a DV certificate is a perfect and cheap solution. Securing more mission-critical sites that collect sensitive data like credit card numbers and social security details is a different story though.

Organisation validation (OV) SSL certificate

As the name suggests, the OV certificate not only validates the domain ownership but also vets the real identity of the organisation to which the domain officially belongs. It builds an extra layer of trust for visitors who have stronger concerns, by displaying the key information about the business. Interested visitors just need to check the details of the certificate to ascertain the credibility of the company.

As compared to a DV certificate, an OV certification requires a more detailed process carried out by an authorised certificate authority that demands and vets key documents representing the legal status of the company. Hence, along with domain ownership, this certificate also assures that it is owned by a legitimate organisation.

Though the issuance process is more expensive and demanding, this type of certificate does empower you to position your company as a legal, real company doing legitimate business. It makes you stand out and even more concerned visitors are able to trust your organisation.

Is OV the right choice for you?: Sites that ask for sensitive data that can be misused by threat actors should obtain this certificate. E-commerce sites with online payment gateways, digital health practitioners, government websites that demand citizens' information, defence-related websites, online trading platforms, or professional networking sites are all the right candidates for obtaining an OV certificate.

Extended validation (EV) SSL certificate

In the digital domain, visuals matter a lot. A company seal, security icons, or even assuring colours (like green) can go a long way in leaving a lasting impression, winning you a big deal or helping you forge business relations with dynamic brands.

The vetting procedure for issuing an EV SSL certificate is quite stringent and involves a manual process as well. It starts by verifying the ownership of the domain. After that, the certification authority asks for your identification number. Next, it gets your legal working contact number from relevant authentic sources. That contact number is manually verified by calling your office and talking with the real person. Only after satisfying all such verification parameters can you get the EV certificate.

Unlike an OV certificate, you don't just get a static site seal with a basic look, but get dynamic seals as well. Additionally, the full legal company name is displayed in the address bar along with a green-coloured padlock. Added to this, the entire address bar turns green as soon as your site loads. All these visible signs vouch for the legality of your firm, build a 'visual comfort zone' and reaffirm the credibility of your organisation.

Such certificates satisfy the sophisticated digital security vetting parameters of global brands and corporate conglomerates. If highly